

a protected room, the trigger gets activated and the program alerts the user.

The good news: this system is scalable up to eight triggers from a single port.

Manas has added a smart touch – an Interactive Voice Response (IVR) program that alerts him if there is a ‘security breach’. The 18-year-old explains: “When nobody answers a call at home, the program picks up the call and behaves like a regular answering machine. However, when I dial a number assigned to the security system, the program behaves like an IVR system. I have a choice of either remote controlling the computer or the security system. The program then tells me whether there has been a security breach or not.”

The program itself is customisable—you can write it to sound an alarm, send an e-mail to a predefined address, and so on. The activity log lets you take a look at everything that’s been happening since you left the room.

Customising can be done in great detail. Shiv will be able to:

- ❑ Receive an e-mail (or an SMS) every hour detailing the scene at home while he is out gallivanting.
- ❑ Disable the system via a phone call at a time when a guest is expected.
- ❑ Program the system to identify window movement in case it’s quite windy. Perhaps even



‘I want a laser-switch system next’

Why a trigger-based security system?

My mom suggested the idea of a burglar system. As for the triggers, I thought using them would be interesting. I felt it was way out of the ordinary.

How long did it take to put this together?
It took just a day.

Are you just another geek?

When I don’t have to go to college, I spend 16 to 18 hours on my computer. But I have other hobbies like

collecting coins and sports cards. I play the piano and the tabla. I also dabble in painting occasionally. Besides, I love to spend time with my friends. Most of the time, though, we talk about technology. And yes, I plan to become a systems administrator.

When you are with your friends, do you use technology terms as swear words?

(Laughs) Not really, but whenever I am irritated by some conversation, I start reciting the value of Pi (3.1415926... which goes on and on and on). The person usually shuts up.

What’s next?

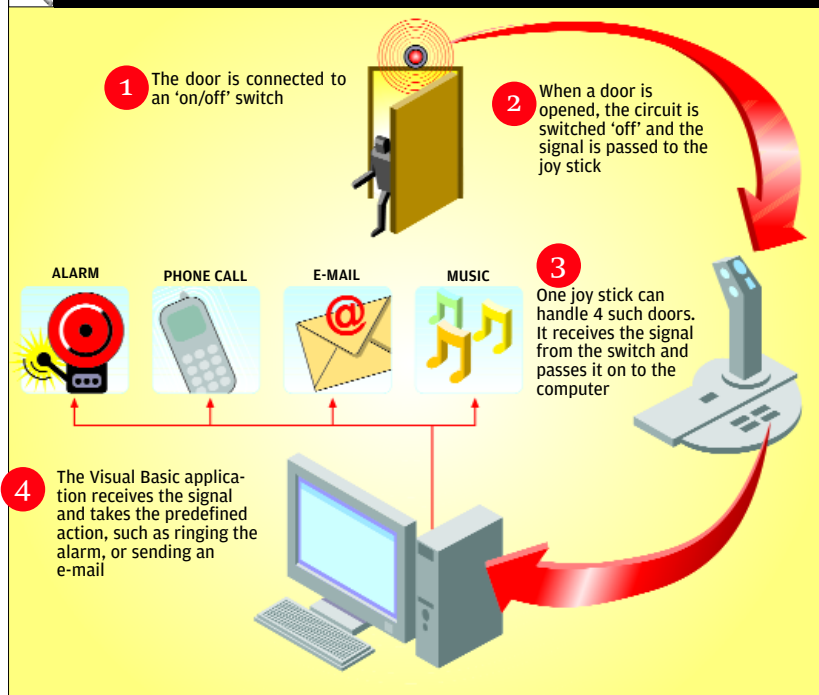
I want to put together a laser-switch based security system—the stuff you see in movies.



Here’s my musketeer!: Shiv with his security system

Photograph: Mery Xavier

How it’s Trigger-Secure



close a door if it has been left ajar due to wind.

- ❑ Get the PC to set off an alarm if an individual uses the PC beyond the allotted time.
- ❑ Get a phone call if someone tries to switch off the PC.

Future track

Shiv says that this system can be upscaled in terms of hardware as well as ideas, although it will be some time before this happens.

For instance, it could ask, “Who is this?” when someone enters the room. The person could then speak into the system, which will have a voice-recognition software that will convert speech into text and send an e-mail to you.

You could also control electrical appliances through the PC, or a phone, or even through e-mail. The possibilities are practically limitless. ■

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Buzzword of the MONTH

Phish Scam

Conmen using phony e-mail messages and fraudulent Web sites lure victims into giving away critical financial data online. Often, phish scam-

mers pose as PayPal, the popular tool for international online commerce payment. Users are fooled into revealing their credit card details when they try to buy online on Web sites that look real and have credi-

ble-sounding domain names. On an average there are around 3000 phishing attacks across the world every month, says the Anti-Phishing Working Group, a body sponsored by Microsoft, among others.